

MOVE AGAIN.

YOUR CHRONIC PAIN GUIDE

Gentle, paced movement for when pain has become part of everyday life, at a pace that's right for you.



Created by Accredited Exercise Physiologists

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3.6M

Australians live with chronic pain

#1

leading cause of disability in Australia

8

gentle exercises to start from

HURT DOESN'T MEAN HARM.

Persisting pain works differently from the pain of a fresh injury. That difference changes how we approach movement.

3-6

Pain is considered chronic or persisting when it continues beyond the expected healing time of an injury, usually longer than three to six months.

1

THE ALARM GETS SENSITIVE

Your nervous system turns the volume up, so it takes less to trigger pain.

2

PAIN ISN'T DAMAGE

Persisting pain often isn't a sign of ongoing harm to your body.

3

AVOIDING MOVEMENT BACKFIRES

Rest brings weakness and stiffness, which makes everyday life harder.

MYTH VS FACT

MYTH

Pain means I should stop moving.

FACT

For most persisting pain, gentle guided movement helps rather than harms.

MYTH

If it hurts, I'm causing damage.

FACT

Persisting pain is usually about nervous system sensitivity, not new tissue damage.

MYTH

Nothing helps long-term pain.

FACT

Graded exercise is one of the most evidence-based ways to improve function.

WORTH SEEING AN AEP IF

✓ Pain has lasted longer than three months

✓ You're avoiding activities you used to enjoy

✓ Pain is affecting your sleep, mood or daily life

The good news: paced exercise can calm an overprotective nervous system and rebuild strength and confidence — even when pain doesn't disappear completely.

FOUR THINGS IT DOES FOR YOU.

Movement doesn't just build strength. It helps retrain an overprotective nervous system and rebuild trust in your body.

1

CALMS THE ALARM

Gentle, consistent movement helps turn down the sensitivity that drives persisting pain.

2

REBUILDS STRENGTH

Gradual strengthening reverses the weakness and stiffness that come with doing less.

3

LIFTS MOOD AND SLEEP

Less tension and more daytime activity support better sleep and steadier mood.

4

REBUILDS CONFIDENCE

Moving well despite some discomfort reduces fear and gets you back to what you value.

PACING, NOT PAIN, GUIDES PROGRESS

Start below your threshold, not at your limit

Increase to a plan, not to how you feel

Mild discomfort is common and usually safe

Sharp or worsening pain means stop and check in

The ESSA-endorsed pacing approach means building activity to a planned schedule rather than to how much pain you feel on the day. That is what breaks the boom-and-bust cycle.

WEEKS 1-2

Building a small, consistent, tolerable routine

WEEKS 3-6

Gradual increases in activity and confidence

WEEKS 6-12

Noticeable improvements in function and quality of life

START HERE.

Low-impact exercises commonly used as a starting point for persisting pain. Start well within your comfort zone and progress gradually with guidance.

1

DIAPHRAGMATIC BREATHING

Slow, deep belly breathing to help calm the nervous system and reduce tension.

3–5 minutes, as needed

2

NECK & SHOULDER ROLLS

Slowly roll your shoulders and gently turn your head side to side within a comfortable range.

2 sets of 8–10 reps

3

CAT-COW STRETCH

On hands and knees, gently arch and round your back to mobilise the spine.

2 sets of 8–10 reps

4

SIT TO STAND TO SIT

From a sturdy chair, stand up fully then lower back down with control, at a pace that feels manageable.

2 sets of 6–8 reps

5

WALL SLIDES

Standing with your back against a wall, slowly slide your arms up and down to support shoulder mobility.

2 sets of 8–10 reps

6

WALKING AT A COMFORTABLE PACE

Walk for a planned, set amount of time, increasing gradually regardless of how you feel that day.

5–15 minutes, most days

7

GENTLE HIP FLEXOR STRETCH

A light stretch through the front of the hip, held gently without forcing range.

2 × 20–30 seconds each side

8

PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION

Gently tense and release muscle groups through the body to support relaxation and reduce tension.

5–10 minutes, as needed



BEFORE YOU START

Work to a planned schedule rather than pushing through on good days and stopping completely on bad ones. Some discomfort during gentle movement is common and usually safe, but sharp, worsening or new pain is a sign to stop and check in with your doctor or Accredited Exercise Physiologist.

PACED, NOT PUSHED.

Consistency and pacing matter more than intensity. Start small and increase on a schedule, not by how much pain you feel that day.

DAY	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
MONDAY	Mobility	Neck & shoulder rolls + Cat-cow + Wall slides
WEDNESDAY	Strength	Sit to stand to sit + Hip flexor stretch
FRIDAY	Full routine	All exercises at a gentle pace, focusing on breathing and control
EVERY DAY	Movement	A short planned walk + diaphragmatic breathing

WEEK 1-2

Establish a small, consistent, comfortable routine you can stick to.

WEEK 3-6

Increase time or reps gradually and predictably, on a set schedule.

BEYOND

A supervised, graded program helps safely build capacity and confidence long-term.

FROM YOUR HEP TEAM

A PROGRAM THAT UNDERSTANDS PERSISTING PAIN

Our Accredited Exercise Physiologists specialise in graded, individualised programs for persisting pain, working with you and your treating team to rebuild movement and confidence.

BOOK ONLINE

www.hobartexercisephysiology.com.au

WHERE THIS COMES FROM.

Every recommendation in this guide is drawn from peer-reviewed research and professional body position statements.

- 01** Exercise & Sports Science Australia (2022) *Exercise for Persisting Pain* [eBook]. Available at: exerciseright.com.au (Accessed: 2026).
- 02** Exercise Right (2021) *Lower Back Pain* [Factsheet]. Exercise & Sports Science Australia. Available at: exerciseright.com.au (Accessed: 2026).
- 03** Exercise & Sports Science Australia (2022) 'Updated position statement on exercise and physical activity for people with hip/knee osteoarthritis', *Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport*.
- 04** Chronic Pain Australia (2023) *Chronic pain in Australia*. Available at: chronicpainaustralia.org.au (Accessed: 2026).

A NOTE ON ADVICE

This guide is for general educational purposes and is not a substitute for individual medical advice. Persisting pain can have many contributing factors, so please speak with your doctor or an Accredited Exercise Physiologist before starting a new exercise program.